

March

*March brings breezes,
loud and shrill,
To stir the dancing
daffodil*

Sara Coleridge



And here are some **did you know?** facts about March

- Named after Mars, the Roman god of war
- Old English names – *Lentmonat*, after the March equinox and all lengthening of days
 - *Hreth-monath* - after the goddess *Hreth*,
 - and *Hyld-monath* – *stormy month*
- Finnish name *maaliskuu* - when earth finally becomes visible under the snow
- Traditional Slovene name *sušec* - the month when the earth becomes dry enough to cultivate
 - It's the first month of spring
In like a lion, out like a lamb



The flower of the month

The birthstones



Aquamarine

and

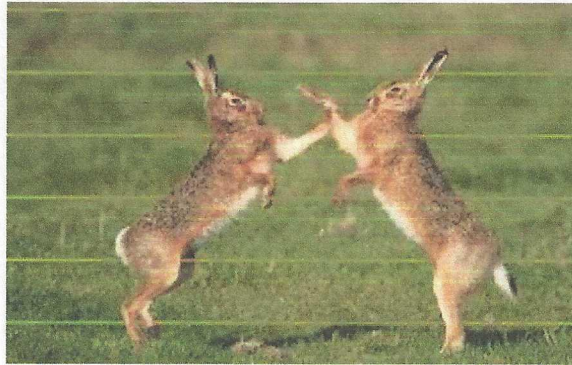


Bloodstone

Symbolising courage

March

To be as **mad as a March hare** is derived from the observed antics, said to occur only in the breeding season, of the European hare in March



Some March dates in 2019

1 St David's Day Traditional to wear daffodils and leeks, symbols of Wales and St



5 Shrove Tuesday/Pancake Day Many places still celebrate with mob football games although the practice largely died out in the 19th Century when football playing on public highways was banned. Off-road celebrations still take place around the country as here in Ashbourne in Derbyshire



Then there are the pancake races with participants racing through the streets tossing pancakes and catching them in their frying pans.

Some of us make do with pancakes for tea!

In Scandinavia, they have almond paste-filled semla buns, and in Belarus, Ukraine and Russia thin pancakes called blini

And Mardi Gras with carnivals all over Europe, and around the world. Anyway the day's for celebrating before the fasting and giving things up for Lent.

March

- 6 **Ash Wednesday** the beginning of the 40 days of Lent
- 15 **The Ides of March** notorious as the date of the assassination of Julius Caesar in 44 BC
- 17 **St Patrick's Day** Parades and the wearing of the green celebrated all over the world
- 20 **The Equinox** the vernal equinox here in the northern hemisphere, when daylight and nighttime are equal all over the planet. Here in Oxford it's timed at 9.58 am.
- 25 **Lady Day** One of our quarter days when, for instance, year-long farming contracts could be renewed. In 1752 'Old Lady Day' of 25 March became 'New Lady Day' on 6 April, when of course our new tax year begins.



Children and young people who were in service (as household servants) were given a day off on that date so they could visit their families or, originally, return to their mother church. The children would pick wild flowers along the way to place in the church or give to their mothers.

Or even bake a Simnel cake to share with the family.



- 29 **Maybe less said the better??**
- 31 **Mothering Sunday** Some of us might remember giving our mums flowers in church or chapel on the Sunday morning?



Then came the US-derived version of **Mother's Day**. Its founder was Anna Marie Jarvis who later on said that she regretted the resulting commercialism.